

Nationalist Conspiracy: Review of Enis Sulstarova's *Samiu dhe Utopia*

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Abstract: *Enis Sulstarova, Samiu dhe Utopia (Tirana: Pika pa sipërfaqe, 2024)*

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The ghost of fascism has returned from the dead. It has been hiding in memories and books, waiting in the dark for the present to summon it back to life. It flickered into view during the Italian occupation, breathed beneath national communism, and was nearly buried in the marginal, self-published newspapers of the 1990s. Now it is stirring beneath the surface. As Gresa Hasa, a PhD researcher at the University of Vienna, argues, Albanian nationalism was always present, but it has recently grown more visible through the return of the diaspora and the reawakening of an older nationalist repertoire. Gresa Hasa sees a diffuse and volatile organization of individuals and small networks that combine ultranationalist rhetoric and sympathy for fascist ideas with intimidation, aggression, and attempts to silence or discredit protesters.¹²

Since May 2026, Albanians have taken to the streets beneath a bewildering array of banners: rainbow, red and black, pink like flamingos, green for the environment, and white for clean underwear. Some of these colors may be unsettling to some; others are openly polarizing.

According to Albania's prime minister, Edi Rama, some protesters are paid by Iran or Russia, serve as victims of foreign propaganda, or are merely caught up in the attention economy of social media and influencers.

Perhaps it is a conspiracy: an attempt to overthrow Rama or destabilize Albania. Russia and Iran would certainly benefit from such disorder, as might Serbia, Greece, or, for that matter, some Albanians themselves.

Was it this kind of conspiracy that Sami Frashëri sought to combat with a counter-conspiracy of his own? In the aftermath of Serbian and Greek independence from the Ottoman Empire, he saw the need for an Albanian state taking shape as both a defense against external designs and a project of political invention. As the neighboring states sought to divide Albanian-speaking communities among themselves, it also divided the Albanians within themselves.

This is the subject of Enis Sulstarova's recent study. A professor at the University of Tirana, Sulstarova reads Sami Frashëri's project, *What Albania Was, What It Is, and What It Will Become*, as a "concrete utopia": an alternative society organized around a moral principle and a new state.

Yet behind the language of utopia lies a more direct scheme. Sami does not merely imagine a better society; he devises a plan for creating an Albanian political subject, uniting it, and securing its survival in a hostile world. The nation-state appears simultaneously as instrument, conspiracy shield, and goal.

¹²Gresa Hasa, LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7498423171436605440/>

This is where the project's conspiratorial character lies. History appears as a circle of forces that divide, impoverish, and threaten Albanians, while the solution requires an organized collective, the *besa*, and a state apparatus capable of overturning this plot.

The enemy may change its name: the empire, local elites, federalism, foreign influences, or any universal project that weakens national belonging. It may even speak Albanian, Russian, or Esperanto. The formula remains the same: the danger is both external and internal, while salvation lies in political unity.

Sulstarova knows that this project does not belong only to the nineteenth century. He therefore defends a programmatic reading of Sami against a dystopian one, asking that the manifesto serve as both a critical mirror and a guide to the future, in an age of depopulation, economic crisis, and global insecurity. At this point, the historian of ideas becomes a political intermediary: he does not consign the utopia to the history books, but revives its conspiratorial energy.

There have even been suggestions that Sami Frashëri was a Freemason or an Illuminatus, as some of the Young Turks like Ismail Qemali were accused of being.¹³ The speculation is not entirely implausible if one follows the continuity from the Rilindja to the communist movement: a hidden political current passing through different historical forms. Mustafa Mustafai. (2026) *Jewish Conspiracies in Albania*. In: Robert Weisal, "Conspiracy theories in Albania"

Yet Sami Frashëri was also a believer, an enlightened Muslim who understood the difference between political goals and the instruments used to pursue them. He borrowed Western forms of mobilization, including their ideas and political projects, but maintained a critical distance from the beliefs of both the Turks and the West. sulstarova, *rratisje* 2006

Elvis Hoxha's afterword extends this conspiratorial logic: circumstances cannot simply be resolved, but they can be transformed through collective will, expressed as knowledge, organization, and political action.

In Sulstarova's book, Sami emerges as the author of a plan still operating behind the scenes. Sulstarova awakens this conspiracy, translates it, and adapts it to the present crisis. As colonial and imperial wars continue to shape an uncertain world, from the interventions of the United States and Russia to the conflicts involving states across the Middle East, the nation-state once again presents itself as the most natural answer. Sami's utopia can therefore return as a conspiratorial solution: not merely a relic of the past, but a political program waiting for its moment.

¹³Nefes, T. S. (2014). *The function of secrecy in anti-Semitic conspiracy theories: the case of Dönmes in Turkey*. In: Conspiracy theories in the United States and the Middle East: A comparative approach, 139-156.